turn in light of these developments. India's chief of army staff General K. Sundarji, with support from the Minister of State for Defence, Arun Singh, launched a mock war drill called Operation Brasstacks in the desert planes of Rajasthan, in November 1986, and mobilised close to 150,000 soldiers to 'test' India's military effectiveness.[129] The move elicited a full military mobilisation by Pakistan in the Punjab sector. Though some Indian officials argue that Rajiv was unaware of the well-planned operation till January 1986, by November the same year he had a good idea that Operation Brasstacks was underway.[130] In January 1986, for instance, on his way to the airport to receive Najibullah—an odd thing for a serving PM to do given Najibullah was months away from becoming president—Rajiv allegedly asked his Minister of State (MoS) for External Affairs, Natwar Singh, whether India 'was on its way to war with Pakistan'?[131] Natwar Singh had no clue, and was appalled by MoS Defence Arun Singh's audacity to go behind the PM's back to initiate the operation. Occurring in context of Pakistan's audacious advance in Afghanistan, covert war with India, a successful nuclear weapons programme, and India's military dash at the Siachen glacier in April 1984, Brasstacks brought India and Pakistan on the verge of war. The worst, however, was still to come. In July 1987, marking the death of Rajiv's conciliatory approach in the region, the Indian army was ordered into Sri Lanka.[132]

Close links with Najibullah offered Rajiv practical measures to undercut Pakistan's growing influence and adventurism. Rajiv and Najibullah's increasingly staunch anti-Pakistan partisanship, and Moscow's shaky support to Kabul in the wake of its impending withdrawal made them partners out of necessity more than choice. The R&AW received KhAD's active support in keeping an eye on Khalistani and Kashmiri militants being trained by the ISI in the tribal areas of Pakistan. KhAD had excellent contacts among Pashtun communities in Pakistan-administered Kashmir who, among other issues, supplied intelligence on anti-India outfits operating from that region. Close collaboration with KhAD also allowed India to stir turbulence in Balochistan and ramp up covert support to the Pashtuns in Pakistan.[133] Even the IB (without informing R&AW) had infiltrated secret agents in ISI-sponsored training camp for Hizb-e-Islami fighters located near the Spin Khwar lake in NWFP in early 1980s, in order to track India-centric militants.[134] The KGB, for its part, encouraged covert collaboration between New